

KF32 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

Orientation springs from a state of calm, and we have been learning how to remain calm in the midst of life’s difficulties. **Calming Breath** meditation helps us cultivate a state of peace, which gives us the option to choose orientation.

Take a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause)* Settle into this experience and experiment. You might begin with a silent prayer. Ask God to train you and help you maintain peace within yourself and in your life. Tell Him that you want to learn to be calm in all of life’s experiments *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Calming Breath

1. Scan for tension

Inhale and exhale for one minute, recognizing and releasing tension in your body and mind. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

2. Use sound and touch

Use the word *CALM* as a centering word. Sing the word, prolonging the “ahm” sound, and find a pitch that feels healing. Allow your body to soften and relax. We can train our bodies to relax immediately in response to a physical signal. So, as you continue with **Calming Breath**, experiment with using touch to signal your body to relax. First, on each hand, try touching together your thumb and one of your fingertips. How does that feel? *(Pause for 5 seconds)* Now bring together both hands, with thumbs and fingertips touching. *(Pause for 5 seconds)* Next, try tapping on the left side of your chest, or just lay your hand over your heart. *(Pause for 5 seconds)* Did any of those signals feel soothing or calming for you? Continue to experiment for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

3. Use only touch

Now, let go of singing the word and just hold the word in your mind while using your physical signal. Continue releasing tension with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

4. Rest

Let go of the word and your physical signal. Rest in the stillness for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Pause.

Our hymn for this lesson is *Spirit of God, Descend Upon My Heart*.

Teach me to love Thee as Thine angels love,
One holy passion filling all my frame;
The baptism of the heaven-descended Dove;
My heart an altar and Thy love the flame.¹

Take a deep breath and gently stretch. Open your eyes and re-engage with the meeting.
(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

All Creation rejoices when we commit to living in reality. Let's continue to explore KF Confession 7:

We commit now to live in reality, choosing to believe rather than judge.

Tell God that you are committed to recognizing the reality of your own life and the lives of others. The Book of Proverbs is a trustworthy guide which, together with your life experience, will train you to rightly interpret what the fruit of your own or another's life reveals. When you see misoriented fruit, you can simply believe it and continue to train hard.

In the world of cause and effect, training is a season of pedaling. It is a time of planting positive seed in order to get positive outcomes. We can plant seed that produces destructive fruit, or we can plant seed that produces fruit that benefits both ourselves and others. This glorious fruit is evidence of a True Self connected to and circulating with a real God. Your **Meeting Preparation Guide** records the many harvests that result from your planting. When you see oriented fruit in your life, you can enjoy it with gratitude. Pat yourself on the back for a job well done.

Whether you are in a season of pedaling or coasting, you can be certain that you will eventually suffer again. Suffering is inherent in every new birth, and at times we just have to mindfully endure suffering until its deep work is completed. In fact, the most powerful kinds of growth can only be released through prolonged suffering—sometimes over years, or even decades. Suffering is part of training hard, so if you are training hard, real suffering is inevitable. However, real oriented suffering is less traumatic than the suffering that we impose upon ourselves by clinging to our pride system and trying to save our Idol's life. If we are suffering because of hurt pride, God has to oppose us, and our suffering becomes torment. But if we choose humility, God is ready to give us gifts of grace. So, when you are suffering, give up your pride and humbly ask God for a gift that will encourage you on your way. Then watch for the gift. I find that these special and personal gifts from God encourage me to endure the difficult process of becoming fully equipped for my joy and mission.

Think about how you might recognize healthy, productive seeds of change in your own life. These seeds

will all have CORE—C-O-R-E—characteristics. C is for Courage; O is for Orientation; R is for Reality; E is for Endurance. To make the most of any challenge, you must be courageous, oriented, engaged with reality, and you must endure. You have probably heard about core muscles and the need for core strength. Without core strength, you are substantially weak; you cannot even stand up. Similarly, without CORE strength, your soul is weak and will be unable to stand in the midst of your suffering. How are you managing your challenges and your suffering? Are you acting courageously? Are you asking, seeking, and knocking for oriented solutions? Are you practicing mindful awareness with gratitude and staying in touch with what is real, or are you generating more suffering through stories, hurt pride, and self-hate? Can you endure uprightly until your oriented path is revealed? Remember CORE—Courage, Orientation, Reality, Endurance—and consider Jesus, who possessed all these core qualities and taught us how to access the redemptive potential of suffering. He exchanged His cross for joy.²

When we are mindfully suffering and choosing to stay in the present moment, we get to learn what is real about ourselves, about the world, and about God. If we judge our suffering, foster illusions, and tell ourselves and others stories which generate emotions that justify unhealthy choices, we disconnect from reality and are not available for God's training. We can't even access His provision. We end up living more in what *should be* than in *what is*. Our discomfort often compels us to imagine a terrifying future, which our fearful and disconnected reasoning convinces us is real. When we imagine this future, we are no longer living in the present moment, where God is. Through the lens of our distorted imagination, we are judging a future that doesn't exist. How can you possibly judge an imagined future when that future is the product of the person that you are right now? Through your KF training, you may be able to see that the person you were is not the person that you are today. Could you have realistically imagined, even few months ago, who you would be today? Your choice to train yesterday is the cause of who you are today. You, in cooperation with God, have begun to change your own life. It's rather exciting to wonder and marvel about what kind of life you may be living a year from now. That sense of wonder is the hope of the glory of God.

When we have CORE muscles, we are no longer helpless victims suffering from illusions about who we *should be* and the kind of life we *should be* living. Rather, we are explorers of what is real. We explore what God is presenting to us now for our training and development. CORE muscles give us the freedom to make oriented choices. We become the cause that sets in motion a redemptive cycle of cause and effect. Sometimes our choice results in a predictable outcome. At other times, the outcome cannot be predicted, and our motivation to make an oriented choice is based solely on our karis relationship with God. We need developed courage to go with God into the not-knowing without attaching to a particular outcome, proving to God both our trustworthiness and our trust in Him. When we choose to do things God's way, we affirm our loyalty to Him, and we demonstrate our determination to let go of our prideful judgments about how things should be.

In your prayers this week, ask God to show you how He wants to use your present circumstances for your training. Ask Him to guide you as you make the oriented choice to keep training in those circumstances, however difficult they may be. Try working through the worksheet **Suffering: An Opportunity to See Yourself**. You might offer your discoveries in the sharing time next week.

KF training teaches us to calm ourselves, choose positive action, and remember how far we have come. This changes our nervous system and our emotions, which in turn changes our experience.

Here is our quote again:

Research has shown that repeated action, learning, and memory can actually change the nervous system physically, altering both synaptic strength and connections. Such changes may be brought about by cultivated change in emotion and action; they will, in turn, change subsequent experience.³

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord, train my CORE muscles for courage, orientation, reality, and endurance. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?”)

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

In the third chapter of his letter, James teaches us to observe our words. Your words tell you a lot about the health of your soul. What comes out of your mouth—not just your words but also your tone and delivery—is a kind of fruit, and that fruit reveals what you carry in your heart all the time. In unguarded moments or in moments of distress, self-hate, or euphoria, your words can tell you and others how your soul is really doing. However, we often do not pay attention to what comes out of our mouths. So, ask trustworthy people to reflect back to you what they notice; this is a time for humility, not self-defense. Remember to celebrate when your spontaneous words reveal the growing health of your soul and when your verbal interchanges with others indicate encouraging progress toward orientation.

Misoriented words proceed from seeds of misorientation that thrive in the chaos of our souls. Our Idol Self wants us and others to believe that our distress is the cause of our misoriented words, tone, and delivery, but in reality, the distress has simply dislodged and released the suppressed hurt, fear, and rage that already lie festering in our soul. We use our distress as a virtue story to justify our choice to unload through our communication the venom that we carry within. Misoriented words and attitudes are the evidence of a diseased soul that is reacting with self-hate to the frustrations of living with limitations in a material world. James wants us to courageously face up to the reality revealed by our words and attitudes in times of distress. We can then choose to press on with the work of healing our souls.

In the Toolbox we talked about the CORE muscles of the soul—Courage, Orientation, Reality, Endurance. When your CORE is weak, you cannot stand in the face of compulsive behaviors, destructive habits, or sudden provocations; every part of you is vulnerable to weakness and injury. Unless you train your CORE muscles to be strong, you will be weak just when you need your strength the most.

In his letter to the Ephesians, Paul teaches us to perpetually keep our enemy in mind. If, however, we choose to live in the lazy illusion that there is no enemy and make no effort to train, we will be vulnerable to enemy attack.

Let’s look at Nancy’s paraphrase of **Ephesians 6:10–18** in which Paul teaches us how to prepare for the good fight against our real enemy.⁴

¹⁰And one more thing, learn to take up your abilities in the Lord and take them up in the strength that comes from doing things His way. ¹¹Put on the complete armor of God, as

when one warrior gifts his armor to another, and move toward the goal of having the ability to stand against the schemes of the slanderer and the Idol Self. ¹²We need this divine armor from God because our battle is not against material creatures, but against the things that rule those creatures, against the actual authorities in their lives, against the governors of their world-system that create this present darkness, and against spiritual things that cause injury in the world beyond this world. ¹³God has passed this battle on to you, but you cannot fight the battle for your own soul without the proper equipment. Therefore, take up the complete armor of God that He has gifted to you so that when those days of injury threaten you, you can stand against the onslaught—and doing all that you can, keep standing.

¹⁴In case you have not understood, you must stand! Wrap your core muscles with truth and cover your vital organs with orientation. ¹⁵Keep your shoes on, prepared to deliver the good news of peace at every moment. ¹⁶And in all that you do, take up the shield of trust—of believing it—with which you can extinguish all the incoming missiles that are thrown at you by those who seek to inflame you and provoke you to imagine and judge that you have been injured. ¹⁷And solemnly receive the helmet of wholeness, which protects your thoughts, declares your loyalty, and identifies you as one who has been rescued from the power of the enemy. Receive also the sword of the Spirit and the breath, which is all that God has spoken about who you are. ¹⁸With a cultivated attitude of sacred prayer, make requests in every moment and with every breath; pray with your spirit. Always keep awake and stay alert with obstinate persistence. Keep making requests concerning the saints—I mean those who are your fellow soldiers and who, like you, have set themselves apart to serve the purposes of God.

Take a deep breath.

If you want to live an oriented life, you must accept the reality that you have an enemy. Your enemy is determined to undermine any effort you make toward restoring your True Self. When you waste your energy searching for a counterfeit glory, you are pridefully opposing God and cooperating with the enemy that seeks to sabotage God's plan for your life, your mission, and your designed glory. Healthy fear of a real enemy motivates us to secure our boundaries and guard the ground that we have gained. It may seem like a paradox, but fear can be your friend. Fear can motivate you to undergo the difficult but necessary training that prepares you to face the enemy and gives you real self-confidence in the fight.

Paul is not saying in this passage that you can never rest. In fact, he is teaching you how to maintain a state of alert relaxation, trusting in the quality of your armor and your training. If you put on God's armor, which is a metaphor for all the oriented qualities that you need for the fight, your enemies both within and without will no longer have power over you. Whether the enemy is Satan, your Idol Self, or the Idol Self of others is immaterial. What is important is that you acknowledge the reality that you have an enemy. Keep learning to stand when things get rough. If you rely on the armor of orientation, you will no longer need to run back to your old habits of relieving tension and restoring pride. You can just stand using your CORE muscles.

You are training yourself to stand in reality with an endurance that is courageous and oriented. When you are under attack, you rarely have to do anything. With courageous, oriented, real endurance, you just stand in your True Self, and pray. You take care of your own business. The more truth and orientation

there is in your life—that is, the more you learn to trust God and do things His way—the more confident you will be when confronted with opposition from the world.

In the past, you may have judged people who are compelled by neurotic needs and self-hate, but now you are able to peacefully believe it and offer the good news of peace by being at peace. With God's armor, you can protect yourself from the fiery missiles of others that seek to pierce your soul and ignite mindless reactions. Just stand, believing rather than judging what people choose and what people do, knowing that you do not have to participate. Spot the fools quickly and circumvent them. Recognize the wise. Walk with them and cling to them. The safest place for you to be is by their side.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord of the armies of God, teach me to stand. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

You might sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume your meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider a distressing situation that you just can't stand. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

Feelings

As you *consider a distressing situation that you can't stand*, recognize any emotional feelings that are present. *(Pause)* Our feelings are ours to teach us about ourselves, to guide us, to show us our limitations, and to train us. They can often be uncomfortable. We are learning to honor our feelings without allowing them to master us. Observe and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Graciously allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness. Notice any struggle you might have with this experience. Do you want to escape, attack, or perhaps drift into self-pity? *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are part of the struggle. They are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission to explore whatever you are experiencing without judgment and use a long exhaling breath to quiet your feelings. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body. What is it doing when you *consider a situation in which you cannot stand*? For example, you might notice what shutting down, craving, or, perhaps, unfairness and rage feel like in your body. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider this situation that you can't stand*. What do you believe when you consider this situation? Do you feel

compelled to judge as good or as evil this “reality check” about your ability to stand? *(Pause)* What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Observe your experience as just information, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore this present distress.
- Welcome the Holy Spirit of truth as He uses your suffering to heal you.
- Welcome your present reality and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.⁵

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I train to stand, I let go of my longing for power and control.
- As I train to stand, I let go of my longing for admiration and affection.
- As I train to stand, I let go of my longing for security and comfort.
- As I train to stand, I let go of my longing for perfection. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time of healing and training together. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You continue to teach us how to stand. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self and mission, with our community and the rest of Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ *Spirit of God, Descend Upon My Heart* by George Croly (1780–1860), www.youtube.com/watch?v=CmWVY4n-wY.

² Heb. 12:2.

³ Maggie Macnab, *Decoding Design: Understanding and Using Symbols in Visual Communication* (How Books, 2008), 174.

⁴ 1 Tim. 6:12.

⁵ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.